

Second vs Third Conditional

CEFR B2

Lesson Pack · summary, worksheet & answer key

Quick answer

Both are imaginary, but they point at different times:

- 1 Second conditional — unreal present or future (If I had money, I'd travel).
- 2 Third conditional — unreal past (If I had had money, I would have travelled).

Imagining now or in general → second (past + would). Imagining a finished past → third (past perfect + would have).

At a glance

	Second conditional	Third conditional
Time	Unreal present or future	Unreal past
If-clause	past simple	past perfect
Result	would + base verb	would have + past participle
Example	If I had money, I'd travel .	If I had had money, I would have travelled .

Learning objectives

- Can choose between the second and third conditional by time reference (CEFR B2).
- Can form both: if + past + would, and if + past perfect + would have.
- Can recognise when a mixed conditional is needed instead.



Practice worksheet

Circle the correct option. Second vs Third Conditional · CEFR B2

Name: _____

Date: _____

1. If I ____ Japanese, I'd apply for the job now.

- | | |
|----------|----------------|
| A. spoke | B. had spoken |
| C. speak | D. would speak |

2. If I ____ Japanese, I would have got that job last year.

- | | |
|----------|----------------|
| A. spoke | B. had spoken |
| C. speak | D. would speak |

3. If she had left earlier, she ____ the train.

- | | |
|----------------|----------------------|
| A. would catch | B. would have caught |
| C. catches | D. caught |

4. If I had a bigger flat, I ____ a dog.

- | | |
|--------------|-------------------|
| A. would get | B. would have got |
| C. will get | D. got |

5. Which sentence is about the PAST?

- | | |
|---|---|
| A. If I were taller, I'd play basketball. | B. If I had trained harder, I would have won. |
| C. If I had a car, I'd drive to work. | D. If I spoke French, I'd move to Paris. |

6. If I ____ about the meeting, I would have come yesterday.

- | | |
|---------|---------------|
| A. knew | B. had known |
| C. know | D. would know |

7. If we ____ more money, we'd buy a house these days.

- | | |
|---------|---------------|
| A. had | B. had had |
| C. have | D. would have |

8. Correct this: 'If I knew, I would have told you.'

- | | |
|---|---------------------------------|
| A. If I had known, I would have told you. | B. If I knew, I would tell you. |
| C. The sentence is already correct. | D. If I know, I will tell you. |

9. If he weren't so rude, people ____ him more. (in general, now)

- | | |
|---------------|---------------------|
| A. would like | B. would have liked |
| C. will like | D. liked |

10. Rewrite about the past: 'If I were rich, I'd help.' →

- | | |
|---|--------------------------------------|
| A. If I had been rich, I would have helped. | B. If I was rich, I'd have helped. |
| C. If I am rich, I will help. | D. If I had been rich, I would help. |

Answer key

Correct answers with explanations · for the teacher

1. **A. spoke** — An unreal present takes the second conditional: 'If I spoke Japanese'.
2. **B. had spoken** — An unreal past takes the third conditional: 'If I had spoken Japanese'.
3. **B. would have caught** — An unreal past result uses 'would have caught'.
4. **A. would get** — An unreal present takes the second conditional: 'I would get a dog'.
5. **B. If I had trained harder, I would have won.** — The third conditional imagines the past: 'If I had trained harder, I would have won'.
6. **B. had known** — An unreal past takes the third conditional: 'If I had known'.
7. **A. had** — 'These days' is present, so use the second conditional: 'If we had more money'.
8. **A. If I had known, I would have told you.** — A finished past needs the third conditional: 'If I had known, I would have told you'.
9. **A. would like** — A general present takes the second conditional: 'people would like him more'.
10. **A. If I had been rich, I would have helped.** — The past version is the third conditional: 'If I had been rich, I would have helped'.